

certain regions. Currently, with steadily decreasing broadband rates and more and more far-flung areas coming under Internet connectivity, this is the least of our worries.

The second point is vital, because if stagnation is not taken care of, the Web runs the possibility of fracturing, or devolving. This can be prevented by using transparent means of putting information on the Web. By transparent I mean the information that you add onto the Web can be seen and used by all. So the question that arises now is: why would you need it to be transparent? The answer is that, if it is not transparent, it will be of no use to people who cannot see it or use it. And if there is information that cannot be seen or used by people, it is useless. It's the same snooze-button-on-smoke-alarm analogy. Useless information on the Web does not support an open Web. It does not help the Web to evolve or grow. It is a bane to the natural process of evolution.

Enter Google.

Google is one company that actually seems to realise the importance of an open Web (there are some others too that I will come to later). The official statement of purpose of Google Inc is to organise the world's information—to make information available to the people who want it. If there is one reason I respect this company, in spite of it doing quite a few things that I personally disagree with in the recent past, it is the fact that it is one among a few firms that not only claims to be working for an open Web, but actually seems to do a lot for the cause. Agreed, the Google search algorithm is kept under layers of secrecy, but as long as it manages to index Web pages correctly, and helps people by providing them usable information as and when they need it, we are happy.

Another remarkably transparent platform for sharing information on the Web is Twitter. Twitter trends and hashtags are a way of getting to know what the world is talking about at any given moment. And the best thing is that you don't need to join Twitter to know what the world is talking about. There may be people who have kept their tweets private, but that does not affect what the entire population is discussing at the moment—the same 'psychohistory' concept—the opinion or purpose of a single individual is of no significance in the broader perspective of how the whole system behaves. We are concerned about the broad trends being followed by the whole system—what an individual has to say is irrelevant.

This brings me to the topic that I referred to at the very beginning and took this huge detour to finally arrive at: open source, and how it is the culmination of all these ideas, when applied to software.

It is rather easy to see the connection now, if you have followed all this logically. Software is different from other products that you buy, like houses or cars. Software engineers form a sizeable fraction of the human population. Together they have a lot of knowledge, but individually know very little. So if someone writes a piece of code for something, there are a few million ways it can be modified and bettered. The good thing

about software is that it can be sent from one part of the world to another very easily and cheaply, unlike other products like cars and houses—which is why the community that works on a piece of software can include developers and coders from all across the globe. To try and implement the whole open source approach in other industries, say the automobile industry, would mean making a car and then making it available to every other car designer and engineer in the world, so that they can make it better. But the difficulty lies in making a car available to everyone in the world, something that is impossible. Software, being just lines of code, can be easily 'made available to everyone'. You host your source code somewhere on the Internet, and millions of developers can download it from anywhere in the world, and then work on it.

Every piece of open source software thus has a growing community of developers who are interested in it, and want to make it better. And there are users all around the world who have faith in what the developers do, and who use the software for their daily activities. Examples abound—browsers, media players, office applications ... you name it, you'll find something. There is open source software for just about anything that anyone would want to do. Why? Because you aren't the first person who needed it. Hundreds or thousands have felt the need before you—and thus, the community has developed something to address this need.

Finally, open source software complements the open Web, and vice versa. Some of the biggest community-based open source organisations are passionate supporters of an open Web, while some of the biggest Web giants support the concept of openness by relying almost entirely on, or supporting, open source software. A good example of the former is the Mozilla Foundation, and of the latter, the aforementioned Google and Twitter.

In the end, one thing is certain. Now and always (or at least well into the near future), the Web will keep changing. It won't steady itself any time soon. If we all do the right things from now onwards, we might help the Web reach a point from where it will be able to evolve self-sufficiently, and maybe transform itself into a self-learning system some day. If however, we do not act responsibly, we can actually stop the Web from evolving altogether. Of course, it would be foolish to say that our actions can bring about drastic changes in the growth of something as massive as the Web this quickly. At worst, or at best, the collective intent of humanity is what will guide the Web towards its final destination, and what that collective intent will be, no one person can tell. We will just have to wait and watch.  **END**

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